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Siaya

Author(S): Cohen, David William, Atiendo Odhiambo, E. S.**Document Type:** Book**Original Page:** 67**Culture (OWC):** [Luo \(FL11\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Eastern Africa**Field Date:** 1978-1982**Coverage Date:** 1900-1989**Place Coverage:** Siaya, Luoland, Kenya**Section Title(S):** The Gorogoro Economy

The pay packet retains number one position in the popularity, chart of any construction site ... Ragged and dusty, they shove and jostle while the queue crawls almost imperceptibly towards the office pigeon hole. They receive their envelopes, rip them open and count two, three times before they are quite satisfied. Then they stuff the hard-earned, long-overdue cash into their ragged clothes; a labourer's outfit may be as emaciated as his body but the pockets are as leak-proof as his stomach. He cannot afford to lose anything.⁷

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In the case of Lewnida, all she could do was cry. But then she had to somehow 'live' on the 30 shillings. What has become known as 'the shilling economy' has taken deep root in the countryside as these women struggle to stretch their remittances to the limit. The value and quantity of goods purchased by an individual woman at Kodiene market can be quite limited: a half litre of kerosene, a box of matches, a slice of Nile perch for five shillings, a quarter kilogramme of sugar, siftings of tea leaves — all this exhausts her 30 shillings. This produces a critical moment. She has yet to buy the staple, maize meal. The sellers of maize meal have steadily reduced the size of the standard measuring tin from two litres to one litre to half a litre, yet all the time the unit of measure is referred to as *gorogoro*. It is the price of the *gorogoro* that has tended to remain constant over the last one and a half decades while the measure has shrunk. The *gorogoro* economy illustrates the diminution of the household's capacity to reproduce itself at acceptable levels of subsistence in Siaya. Members of the elite, when driving from Nairobi to Uyoma, make a point of not stopping at the markets nearest to their homes.

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Begging by women, directly or through joking relationships, is no longer a hidden activity at these markets. Here, the differentiation of wealth becomes palpable, and expressive.

The intensification of the *gorogoro* economy has been accompanied by changes in the production of meals and in the nature  68 of sociability in households around the serving of food. In the rural household the meal has come closer to being a ration than a feast; indeed, a woman in the countryside may be preparing food in a way similar to that of her husband away at work when he prepares his evening meal. Hunger in Siaya also means that the mid-day repast disappears from the daily regimen, much as the inflation of food costs has eliminated the mid-day meal from the regimen of the low-paid worker in Nairobi. Elaborate and collective preparations of meals are reserved for funerals and political banquets. At times when the grain stores are low, food may be prepared and served quickly soon after dawn and at dusk to avoid the embarrassment of not being able to offer hospitality to kin and friends passing by the home. Some people in Siaya remember their mothers preparing and serving meals at night as a way of conserving scarce supplies during times of famine.

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7. Meja Mwangi, *Going Down River Road* (London, Heinemann, 1976), p. 164.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



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